



Pitt Research Consultation Presentation

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**Pitt Research**

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It's Possible at Pitt

Learn how Pitt faculty combine technology and creativity to transform education and research.

EXPLORE OUR 2023-24 ANNUAL REPORT

RESEARCH FOR A BETTER FUTURE

- Central hub for finding information about research-related topics, opportunities, and funding at the University of Pittsburgh
- Facilitates cutting edge research and infrastructure for industry collaboration
- Primarily funded through grants, private partnerships, and institutional funding
- Client: Shannon Durkin, Pitt Research Senior Director of Communications
- Target users:
 - Researchers
 - Funding agencies
 - Academics

Heuristic Methods

1) Visibility of system status	Communicates current program state and provides timely feedback.	search bar does not show possible results/searches until users hit enter
2) Match between system and real world	Uses language, concepts, and conventions familiar to the user.	the feature image is odd it is not really research oriented and the women is standing there awkwardly. The "our team picture" does not match what it would usually be
3) User control and freedom	Provides user navigation and tool affordances.	main sections of the site can be accessed from the top or bottom
4) Consistency and standards	Follows platform conventions/best practices and functions in consistent manner.	does not show trending/recent/possible searches, cannot always return to pitt research home by clicking logo in top left (logo is also not always there) takes users to different sites and different parts of the site without showing a path, users can not always return to pitt research website without using the browser, has traditional website layout
5) Error prevention	Eliminates error-prone conditions.	a user finding themselves in a state where errors can occur is pretty much not possible unless the "error made" was a misclick on a link to another page/site, in that case the error is prevented by proper link documentation
6) Recognition rather than recall	Makes use of patterns, context, and cues to aid user decision making.	
7) Flexibility and efficiency	Allows users multiple means of access and multiple ways to complete tasks.	there are multiple ways to get to different pages and lots of linking widgets/responsive design allows for good function on multiple devices
8) Aesthetic and minimalist design	Makes use of negative space, alignment, repetition, proximity, and contrast. Constrains content. .	too much negative open space especially at the top
9) Error recognition and recovery	Delivers error messages and offers solutions.	No error messages/no scenario where error messages would be necessary/no forms within this website
10) Help and documentation	Provides help and documentation.	

- Used **Nielsen and Molich 10 Usability Heuristics** to provide framework in our Heuristic evaluation
- Using Heuristics gave us structure and flexibility when researching the usability of a site without yet user testing.
 - Ideal for early stage testing when resources are limited

Results



RESEARCH FOR A BETTER FUTURE

- Positives:
 - Major navigation features visible and available at top and bottom of pages
 - Few opportunities for user error
 - Flexible user interaction
- Moderate:
 - Images feel awkward and mostly unrelated to research
 - Language and design could reflect research more
- Negatives:
 - Search functionality lacks instant feedback
 - Homepage isn't clear or organized
 - Inconsistent logo behavior (not always clickable or present)
 - Navigation buttons often take you to other Pitt websites with no warning

Siteimprove Report



Accessibility score



SEO score



Performance score



Page optimization score



Accessibility

An accessible website widens your reach and strengthens your brand's credibility. See how your site stacks up against the WCAG standard.

A-level 100/100

AA-level 100/100

AAA-level 100/100

Overview of automated checks completed

We have checked all the different elements on your page, including forms, images, and links. Here you can see how the checks are categorized by "passed" or "failed" occurrences within each conformance level.

Status	A	AA	AAA	Total
Passed 1	107	71	32	210
Failed 1	0	0	1	1

What's Good:

- Passed all automated checks at A, AA, and AAA WCAG levels (only 1 failure overall).
- Forms, images, and links meet accessibility guidelines.

Recommendations:

- Manual Testing: Although automated testing is excellent, consider further manual testing with assistive technologies to identify any issues that automation may miss.
- Address the one failed AAA-level element, even though AAA is not strictly required, to further bolster inclusive design.



SEO

Competition for organic search traffic is fierce. Optimize your search engine rankings by creating content that both people and search engines can navigate easily.



Improve Mobile Optimization:

- Ensure proper viewport settings.
- Avoid fixed-width content.
- Improve font scaling for mobile.
- Optimize tap target sizes and spacing.

Fix Technical SEO Issues:

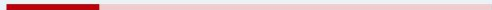
- Add missing or poorly formatted **meta titles and descriptions**.
- Use **descriptive, unique H1 tags** for every page.
- Ensure all internal and external links are crawlable.



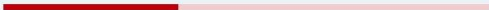
Performance

A website experience free of friction and disruptions is an absolute must for improving conversion rates, generating more leads, and increasing revenue.

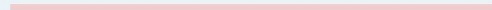
First content (FCP) 2/10



Speed index (SI) 4/10



Largest content (LCP) 0/25



Interactive (TTI) 2/10



Blocking time (TBT) 25/30



Layout shift (CLS) 15/15



Optimize LCP:

- Defer loading of heavy images or videos.
- Compress large assets.
- Use **lazy loading** for offscreen elements.

Preload Critical Resources:

- Fonts, hero images, or important styles/scripts can be preloaded to improve FCP and TTI.



Ads

Don't let conversion blockers like broken links, slow loading pages, and unsafe domains, run your ad campaigns off the tracks. Make sure your site is designed to convert.

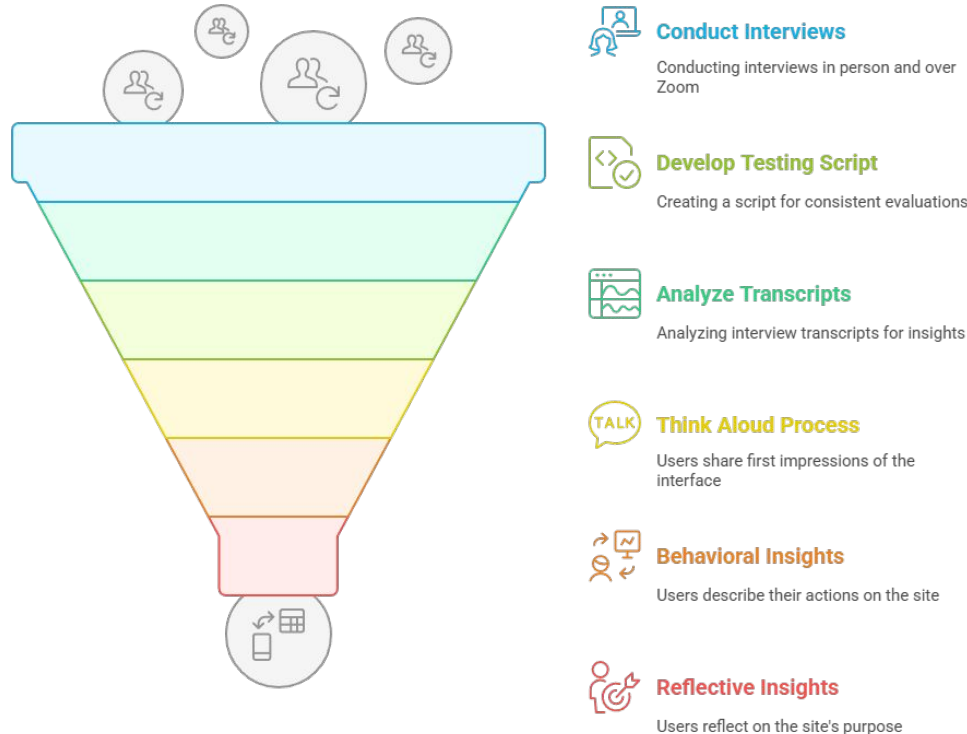


Recommendations:

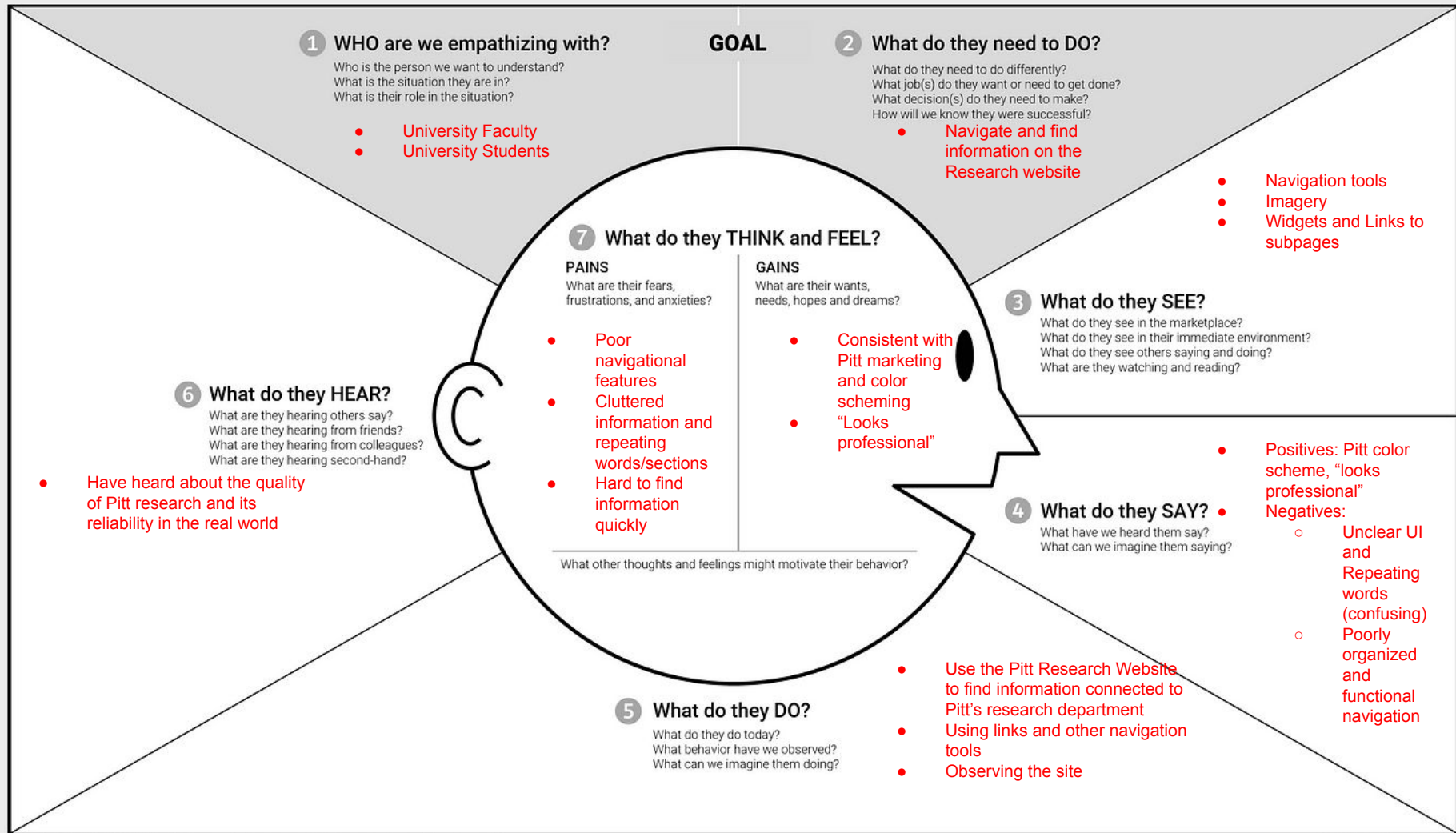
- **Fix broken links or 404s** that may disrupt conversions.
- **Improve call-to-action (CTA) visibility** on key landing pages.
- Ensure ad landing pages load quickly and are **mobile responsive**.

User Research Methods

User Testing Process Funnel



- Recruited a diverse group of users across the university
 - undergraduate
 - graduate
 - research faculty
 - research assistants and associates
- Conducted in person and ZOOM interviews
- Gathered user impressions
- Users participate in 2 scenarios
- Gathered data for analysis and triangulation



Strengths

- Site Aesthetics
 - Users praised the color scheme, font, large visual tiles, and overall layout
- Layout of Some Pages
 - Pages like Pitt Research Concierge, By The Numbers, and Proposal Editing Service were seen as direct and effective
- Consistency with other Pitt Websites
 - Users liked how the website follows Pitt Website standards

RESEARCH AT PITT

By the Numbers

National Rankings

#6

NIH Funding Received by U.S. Universities

#17

in R&D Expenditures (NSF HERD Survey)

#14

in U.S. Utility Patents Received by U.S. Universities

Sponsored Research

The Proposal Editing Service offers a full range of proofreading and copy-editing services for all types and sizes of externally sponsored funding proposals.

▼ What is this service?

▼ Who is eligible?

▼ How do I submit an editing request?

▼ When will the edits be returned?

▼ How do I schedule virtual office hours with the Proposal Editor?



Submit a Request »

Please use our [form to request proposal editing services](#) and attach required



Contact »

Christine Barberio
pittresearchproposaleditor@pitt.edu

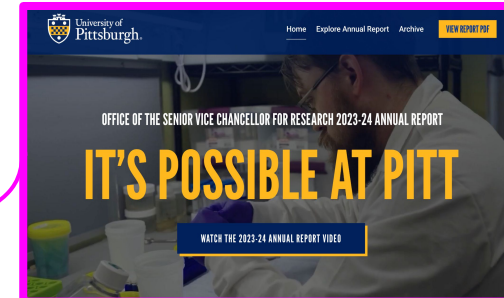
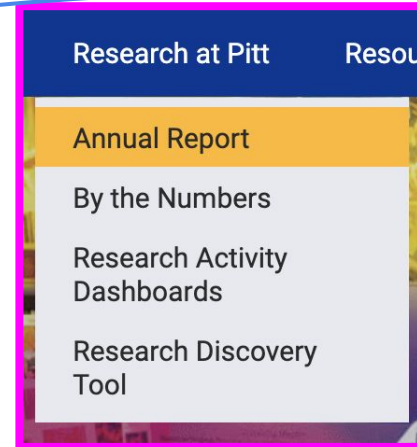
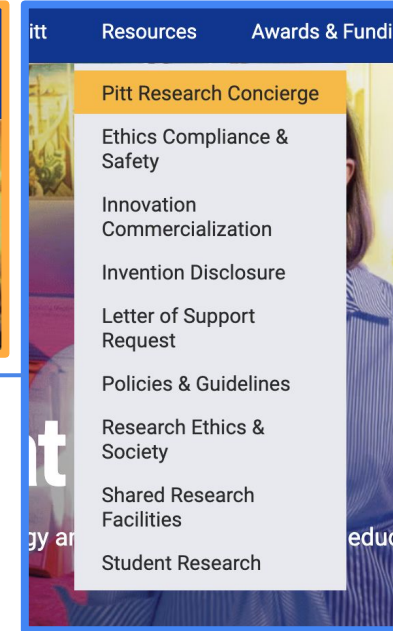
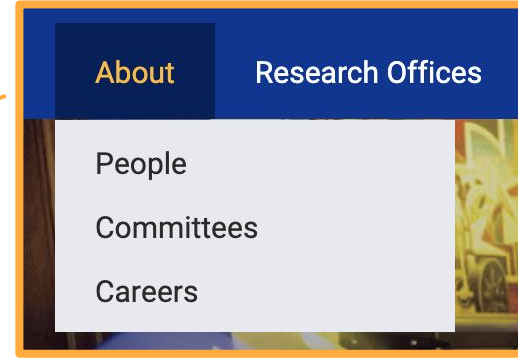


Resources »

- [Proposal Writing Resources](#)
- [Proposal Preparation Checklists, Proposal](#)

Weaknesses

- Confusion on purpose of site
 - Users wanted a page explaining the purpose of the website and Pitt Research
 - Pictures on the site do not inform users about Pitt Research
- UI terminology lacks clarity
 - Pitt Research Concierge should be Pitt Research Services
- Navigation is not well structured
 - Users had to click through multiple sections to locate specific information
 - Users ended up on other sites and could not get back to Pitt Research



Recommendations



Pitt Research



About

Research Offices

Research at Pitt

Resources

Awards & Funding

Partnership

News

High-Priority Issues

- Revisit label descriptions ensuring they are clear and descriptive
- Everything should be integrated into one website
- Key information should be easily accessible

Medium-Priority Issues

- The menu structure should be simplified and the search bar should be in a more noticeable position
- Pitt Research should add a page explaining their mission and the purpose of the site

Low-Priority Issues

- Users should always be able to see the path they took to get to a page
- Pictures should illustrate what Pitt Research does
- Hamburger menu does not need to show up when tabs do